

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

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The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

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The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of kintsugi accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
View and download this photo in full color at:
ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

THE UNEXPECTED GIFTS HIDDEN IN YOUR STRUGGLES

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

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echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

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These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

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experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

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Rational Work Only Produces Rational Results

The unexpected path to extraordinary achievement.

How to Receive a Nobel Prize

Richard Feynman was a physicist who, at one point in his career, was in a bit of a slump. He lamented how he used to enjoy physics because he “used to play with it.” Specifically, he recalls how “it didn’t have to do with whether it was important for the development of nuclear physics, but whether it was interesting and amusing for me to play with.”

He used to treasure tinkering with physics, having that lightness in his work. But since his joy had faded, he resolved to stop approaching physics too seriously.

Feynman rediscovered that lost spark while sitting in the cafeteria. He noticed a student fooling around and throwing a plate in the air. He thought about this rotating plate and came up with some ideas about the physics of what was happening.

He approached his colleague Hans and said, “Hey Hans, I noticed something interesting here... The plate goes around...” and showed him the accelerations.

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Hans replied, “Feynman, that’s pretty interesting. But what’s the importance of it? Why are you doing it?”

Feynman responded, “Huh! There’s no importance whatsoever! I’m just doing it for the fun of it!”

That’s a key line: “I’m just doing it for the fun of it.” Feynman continued to work on it and reflected on how there was “no importance to what I was doing, but ultimately there was. The diagrams and the whole business that I got the Nobel Prize for came from that piddling around with the wobbling plate.” This state of playful creativity helps create what the pioneering psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi calls a flow state.

By focusing on playful exploration, Feynman became more creative, which led him to win a Nobel Prize. Similarly, Apple, Google, YouTube, Facebook, Airbnb, WhatsApp, and countless other significant businesses all began as side projects pursued by their founders just for fun.

What do you do purely for fun? Which activities cause you to lose track of time because you are so immersed in them? Imagine doing this work instead of clocking in and clocking out. Imagine having fun all day and receiving the equivalent of a Nobel Prize for your work, just like Feynman did.

How to Work Like Richard Feynman

Do you ever wonder if you’ll hit your targets to keep earning a respectable salary at an established company? That’s a very different approach from the one Feynman adopted. He was less concerned about the outcome and more interested in fully exploring a compelling idea.

Working like Feynman means your focus is on the quality of your work without burdening your mind about the specific outcome it may produce. In this state, you are able to produce your most inspired work, which is usually your best work. But when your work is required to produce a specific outcome, your focus narrows, resulting in work that is more likely to be bland, standardized, and predictable.

RATIONAL WORK ONLY PRODUCES RATIONAL RESULTS

This effect occurs in many domains. For example, observe how elite athletes — golf players, tennis players, and even chess grandmasters — can choke and surrender a winning advantage by overthinking what they're doing. The desire to win becomes so strong that it distracts them from properly concentrating on what they are doing.

In contrast to being focused on an outcome, consider how you feel when you do work simply because you find it inherently enjoyable. In this state, there is a sense of effortlessness in the actions you take. You get in touch with a deeper form of energy. You start to glide. It's like being a musician in an orchestra, sensing the symphony and playing perfectly in tune. As Feynman said, "It was like uncorking a bottle: Everything flowed out effortlessly."

Take a moment to reconnect with yourself and consider —

*When was the last time you went for a walk in the rain?
When was the last time you smelled the earthy perfume of the forest?
When was the last time you took in the golden rays of a sunset?
When was the last time you experienced a moment that took your
breath away?
When was the last time you simply paused to be grateful for all
you've got?*

Reflect on these moments. Channel this energy into new activities.

*Go to the beach and walk barefoot through the sand.
Write a heartfelt letter to someone who matters to you.
Dance to your favorite song with reckless abandon.
Spend time with people who make you feel truly seen and heard.
Cook your favorite dish.
Read a biography of someone you admire.
Laugh with young children.
Gaze at the stars.
Meditate in the silence of the night.
Listen to the sound of the rain.
Ponder the infinite size of the universe.*

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Embrace the moments that make you feel fully alive. As you are immersed in one such moment, pause, pinch yourself, and remind yourself that this is living, that this is why you are here. If you do this frequently enough, you will no longer tolerate meaningless activities that rob you of this blissful state.

What if you cannot find this state in your work? What if your occupation only brings you bitterness and angst? In that case, you almost certainly need to start looking for another line of work because your discontent will infect your work and prevent you from realizing your full potential. If you are purely rational at work, you will not produce anything more than rational results. The world deserves more than lifeless inputs. The world wants you to engage your heart. The world wants you to create work with your entire being.

When your work comes from your heart, it will be felt much more deeply than anything logic can produce. Mine your work from the depths of your being, and you will create something far purer and more energized than anything logical thought can output. The degree of emotional commitment you invest in the input will determine the degree of excitement others experience in the output.

For some, the logical path is where they find their flow. Logic is a powerful tool when it brings clarity, structure, and rigor to our thinking. But logic alone can strip away the layers of depth that give life its color and vibrancy. It is blind to the emotional nuances, the spark of creativity, and the intangibles that make a work truly exceptional. Without emotional awareness, logical work can feel sterile and predictable, leading to outcomes that are technically correct yet cold and impersonal. Let's consider some examples that contrast the heart with the logical mind.

Podcasts created with love don't just deliver information; they provide valuable insights. Translations done with love don't merely provide a literal interpretation but instead capture the nuances and emotions of the original text. Legal advice given with love is more than just technically correct; it's supportive and responds to the emotional needs of the client.

Music composed with love travels beyond the ears, all the way to the heart. Events organized with love don't just inform or entertain; they create memories that are treasured forever.

Expressions of the heart always outweigh explanations of the mind because the mysteries of the heart have an inexplicable way of transcending the confines of logic. Work ought to be a structure through which your true self expresses its love. Once you reach this point, you cease working for external validation and begin to do things purely because they are inherently worth doing.

Money will come and go. People will come in and out of your life. Possessions can get lost or stolen. But the experience of creating work from your heart can never be taken away from you.

Think twice before you accept a job that is merely "good enough."

If you work with love, then maybe — just maybe — you may reach the point where your work assumes the character of the Spanish concept of *duende*. This is the unmistakable intense energy you feel radiating from a person who delivers an awe-inspiring performance that baffles rational understanding. Such performances take your breath away, make the hair on the back of your neck stand up, and leave you close to tears. These masters exhibit such high vitality in their work that they often appear much younger than their actual age. The love of their craft seems to rejuvenate their body and mind, causing their biological age to be far lower than their actual age.

It takes time to attain the level of greatness characterized by the concept of *duende*. You don't wake up one day and start juggling seven balls. It takes many years. It takes dedication. If you don't enjoy the process, you have no chance; you're finished before you even take the first step.

Choosing your work doesn't require a performance for a crowd. It doesn't have to be fancy work either. It could be as simple as a love of repairing cars. Or you might love doing math. Or maybe sewing and creating dresses brings you great joy. Or you might love building a team.

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No matter how plain, simple, or ordinary your work may appear on the outside, when you *feel* it deeply, you give it the care and attention it deserves. Your peaceful and gentle breath brings your complete conscientiousness to your work. You discover that your work is inextricably connected to your existence. As your work helps you unravel the mystery of your heart, as you become more whole with your being, you feel more deeply the profound richness of the human experience.

But then someone very rational tells you not to study history because “it won’t be good for your future.” You must reply, “I’m sorry, I love history — it makes my heart sing. There’s nothing in the world I want to do more than study history.”

Or perhaps another lost soul says to you, “Why do you like painting? Why don’t you get a real job?”

This is a question you cannot answer. There simply does not exist any answer to the question, “Why do you love painting or dancing or sewing or math or building a team?” It’s a bit like asking, “Why were you born in your current form and not as a different person?” We don’t know. You just came out the way you did. Similarly, there is no logical reason that can justify what brings you joy. The mysteries of the heart cannot be reduced to any rational explanation. The best you can do is accept it and embrace it. Know this —

When you love life, you radiate that loving energy onto others.

When you feel joy, you radiate that warm joy onto others.

When you follow your intuition, you radiate that inner calm onto others.

When you live your truth, your presence alone can inspire others to discover their truth.

When you find this work, you will feel it. It won’t resemble labor at a random job. It’s like watching a sunrise. It’s pure joy. It’s a privilege. It’s an honor to be able to do it every day. It’s a visceral feeling, like you are finally swimming with the current instead of against it. It’s like you’re running with a tailwind propelling you forward instead of a headwind

blowing you backward. Your adapted self disappears because your true self is completely absorbed in what you are doing. In this state, you are so intensely focused that nothing can distract you. You are peaceful. Light. Serene. Time distorts itself and seems to travel much faster than usual. Work seems like play. The creative sparks built into this play produce brilliant results. If your work doesn't feel deeply right, it's probably not the work for you.

It is the pursuit of this feeling, not the “seven strategies for success” nor any hack you read on social media, that will place you on the path to extraordinary success.

The Hidden Path to Extraordinary Success

Winning a Nobel Prize is great. Fame has its benefits. But the true masters escaped the adapted self and were driven by something deeper than trophies or money. They wrote because they had to write. They composed because they had to compose. They were compelled by a feeling they neither understood nor could explain but which they knew was deeply right.

When Phil Ivey won the World Series of Poker, he could have easily taken the huge prize money and celebrated with friends into the night. Instead, he went to his hotel room and reviewed every hand with peers to see where he could improve. When psychologist Daniel Kahneman won the Nobel Prize in economics, he could have basked in the unusual glory of winning a prize outside his own field. Instead, Kahneman invited colleagues to disprove his theories. When Magnus Carlsen played Levon Aronian in the final round of the 2013 Sinquefeld Cup, an elite chess tournament, he could have guaranteed tournament victory by agreeing to the draw offer. Instead, at the risk of losing, Carlsen chose to keep playing and ultimately prevailed to win the game.

Ivey, Kahneman, and Carlsen all embraced the mystery rather than the manifestation. Meaning, they were fascinated with the elegance of their craft, not the prizes of their pursuits. The mark of a champion is

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a humble spirit funneling intensity into the art, into the creation, into getting it right for the sake of getting it right and nothing more. If there is a prize, so be it, but it is never the focus. Meanwhile, the pretender obsesses over the prize, and in doing so, never becomes a champion.

The true masters remain unsatisfied with their results, not because they are ungrateful, but because their devotion to the craft leaves no room for complacency. Until you fall in love with the process, no amount of fame, money, or applause will bring you lasting fulfillment. Recognition without mastery feels hollow.

Are you looking to become a chef so that you can become a famous celebrity? Or do you love cooking and seeing the joy you bring to people when they love your food? Do you want to build a business to gain power and make money, or do you love the challenge of working with a team to solve problems and create something greater than yourself? Do you want to become a scientist to win a Nobel Prize, or like Feynman, do you love the process of discovery?

Extraordinary success rarely comes from merely setting extraordinary goals. Instead, it emerges unexpectedly from acts that bring you extraordinary joy.

Let's use the following reflection to consider how you can bring joy into what you are doing right now.

The Rational Trap

1. *What is the rational work that I do that produces rational results?*

- To identify rational work, list everything that you do, without judging your ideas. Sometimes your best insights come after you've emptied your mind.
- Identify one task you do because it has to be done, not because it energizes you. Which routine tasks feel repetitive or do not help you grow?

2. *What is one small step I can take tomorrow to bring more joy into my current work?*

- Brainstorm one small, actionable step you can take tomorrow to add joy and creativity to your work.
- Is there a way to make a task at work more stimulating by making it more challenging?

Notice how the rational work above is different from the playful exploration that led Feynman to a Nobel Prize. Similarly, Apple, Google, YouTube, Facebook, Airbnb, WhatsApp, and countless other major companies were set up as side projects. If you were to engage in playful exploration, what is a side project that you could do?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to exceed the suggested duration if you wish. This reflection is intentionally brief because small, consistent changes lead to life-changing results.

Write Your Reflections Here

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- ☐ I have identified the rational work that produces rational results.
- ☐ I have found one small step I can take to bring more joy into my current work.

In the Next Chapter...

In this chapter, we looked at how to bring more joy into your work. But how do you know what will bring you the most joy? That's the topic for the next chapter.

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat